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ART BASEL CITIES: BUENOS AIRES



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Art Basel Cities: Buenos Aires

The world converged on the Argentine capital for a spotlight moment that foregrounded art and cultural exchange

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Eduardo Basualdo
Perspective of Absence, 2018
Rio de la Plata, Buenos Aires

Gallery Weekend Buenos Aires was presented by arteBA Fundación and Meridiano, the Argentine chamber of art galleries, in collaboration with the Buenos Aires City Government.

Art Basel Cities works with 22 local Cultural Partners chosen by Cecilia Alemani: arteBA, as Lead Cultural Partner, Meridiano, CCK–Centro Cultural Kirchner, Centro Cultural de la Memoria Haroldo Conti, Centro Cultural Recoleta, Colleción de Arte Amalia Lacroze de Fortabat, El Moderno–Museo de Arte Moderno de Buenos Aires, Faena Art Center, FoLa–Fototeca Latinoamericana, Fundación OSDE, Fundación Proa, La Ira de Dios, La Verdi, MALBA–Museo de Arte Latinoamericano de Buenos Aires, MNBA–Museo Nacional de Bellas Artes, Móvil, MUNTREF–Museo Universidad Tres de Febrero, Museo Sívori, Museo Xul Solar, Parque de la Memoria, URRA–Residencias de Arte, and Usina del Arte.

Launched in March 2016, Art Basel Cities is a global initiative that engages with selected cities to explore and expand their cultural ecosystems. The first partner city is Buenos Aires, a premier hub for the visual arts in South America. Art Basel Cities: Buenos Aires celebrates the city's dynamic cultural life, bridging the international and Argentine art worlds through a series of professional collaborations, projects, and exchanges.

The core elements of the multiyear collaboration were introduced in November 2017, and comprised initiatives to help facilitate professional collaborations, catalyze support for cultural projects, and promote the Argentine art scene to Art Basel's extensive network.

From September 6 to 12, 2018, Art Basel Cities Week offered Argentine and international visitors the opportunity to discover the city's art life through public art, special exhibitions, and events. The citywide experience *Hopscotch (Rayuela)* was accompanied by an extensive lineup of talks and an ambitious Cultural Partner Program organized with 22 of the city's leading arts institutions, associations, and nonprofits. These events received almost 33,000 visitors over the span of seven days, including 100 international participants in a Cultural Immersion trip organized by Art Basel to offer a deeper engagement with the central figures of the city's art world. The agenda was rounded out by Gallery Weekend Buenos Aires, with 40 participating galleries, and BA Photo, an art fair specializing in photography.

Launched in September 2017, the Art Basel Cities: Buenos Aires Talks Program takes place throughout the year, coinciding with key cultural activities. Complementing Art Basel Cities Week, the August–September 2018 Artist Talks featured Eduardo Basualdo, Gabriel Chaile, David Horvitz, Juliana Huxtable, Leandro Katz, Guillermo Kuitca, Luciana Lamothe, Santiago de Paoli, Mariela Scafati, and Sara VanDerBeek & Chelsea Spengemann representing the estate of Stan VanDerBeek. Additional Masterclasses featuring leading thinkers and international artists were offered to the city's art professionals and university students. In September 2018, the session topics included "Surviving the First Three Years as an Emerging Gallery"; "Crowdfunding"; "Art Writing and Communication"; "Building the Art Ecology of Tomorrow"; and "Imagining the Museum of the Future." Speakers included Charles Desmarais, Andrew Goldstein, Patton Hindle, María Mercedes Gonzàlez, András Szàntò, and Diana Wechsler.

To find out about Art Basel Cities and Art Basel Cities: Buenos Aires, please visit www.artbasel.com/cities.

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Gabriel Chaile
Diego (Portrait of Diego Núñez), 2018
La Boca, Buenos Aires



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Barbara Kruger
Untitled (No puedes vivir sin nosotras / You Can't Live Without Us), 2018
Silos de la Antigua Junta Nacional de Granos, Puerto Madero, Buenos Aires



A Citywide Exhibition to Create Physical and Emotional Encounters

Cecilia Alemani, Artistic Director of Art Basel Cities: Buenos Aires Week, recalls some aspects of the manifold *Hopscotch* (*Rayuela*) exhibition that proposed site-specific works, experiential installations, and live performances throughout the city of Buenos Aires, connecting the visual arts, urban spaces, and the city's histories in unexpected ways.

Hopscotch (Rayuela) borrows its name from the 1963 experimental novel by Argentine writer Julio Cortázar, which follows a nonlinear narrative that can be read in multiple sequences.

Hopscotch (Rayuela) spanned the neighborhoods of La Boca, Puerto Madero-Costanera Sur, and Palermo-Recoleta from September 6 to 12, 2018. Its participating artists were Eduardo Basualdo (Argentina), Pia Camil (Mexico), Maurizio Cattelan (Italy), Gabriel Chaile (Argentina), Alex Da Corte (USA), Santiago de Paoli (Argentina), Narcisa Hirsch (Argentina), David Horvitz (USA), Leandro Katz (Argentina), Barbara Kruger (USA), Luciana Lamothe (Argentina), Ad Minoliti (Argentina), Eduardo Navarro (Argentina), Alexandra Pirici (Romania), Mika Rottenberg (USA), Mariela Scafati (Argentina), Vivian Suter (Guatemala), and Stan VanDerBeek (USA).

Cecilia Alemani is the Donald R. Mullen, Jr. Director & Chief Curator of High Line Art, the public art program presented by the nonprofit organization Friends of the High Line in New York City. She was the curator of the Italian Pavilion at the 2017 Venice Biennale.

CLÉMENT DIRIÉ What is your first memory when you think of *Hopscotch*?

CECILIA ALEMANI I immediately think about Eduardo Basualdo's *Perspective of Absence*. Walking this 800-meter-long pier in the middle of the Río de la Plata—it takes 20 minutes to get to the end where the artwork was staged—looking at the sunset, and then turning around and looking at the city from a completely different perspective was a real experience. This work really embodied one of the key aspects of *Hopscotch* and of the Art Basel Cities: Buenos Aires initiative, which was to produce physical and emotional encounters between artworks, artists, audiences, and the city itself.

CD How did you find this place? And more generally how did you work to find the project's multiple locations?

CA I was not unfamiliar with Buenos Aires when the Art Basel Cities team invited me to be Artistic Director. I had visited Buenos Aires twice: first in 2001 as a tourist, then in 2014 to participate in a talk at the arteBA fair. To prepare *Hopscotch* of course I did a lot of research; I read many novels and travel books. I basically did a lot of visits. I would ask every artist I met: "Do you have in mind a place, a building, a square where you would like to see art, or would love to do a project?" Eduardo told me about the old pier from the 1930s managed by a fishermen's club, the Asociación Argentina de Pesca. Many artists mentioned the Costanera Sur area, a large ecological reserve located behind Puerto Madero. As a result of landfilling projects the wetlands of the Río de la Plata became this very beautiful park. It is the natural side of the city and it interested me a lot because Buenos Aires doesn't look at the river very much. Rather it looks backward, inward. *Hopscotch* was organized along a sort of belt running from La Boca north to the Planetario Galileo Galilei in Palermo through Costanera Sur. The idea was really to show a lesser-known side of the city.

CD As you describe it, *Hopscotch* had three main goals. The first was to nurture a dialogue between local and international art scenes; the second was to think about what public art could be in today's Buenos Aires, and the third was to enable people, even the *porteños*, to look at the city in a different way. How did you accomplish this?

CA The aim of the Art Basel Cities: Buenos Aires initiative was to highlight the wonderful artistic ecosystem of Buenos Aires and to build new relationships with the global art landscape through my curation and all the events, talks, and workshops. The scene is vibrant and has its own cultural identity—which is something I greatly appreciate. There is a real diversity of voices. When you go to New York, everyone is formed and educated in the same way. Argentine artists have developed their own artistic language and tend to be very resourceful. They are working—within a complicated economic and social context—through opportunities, looking for what kind of material, what kind of situation can be "used" for their artworks. Someone like Luciana Lamothe, who works with industrial material like pipes and scaffolding, is a great example of that. For *Hopscotch* she presented *Starting Zone,* an open-air tower in the Plaza República Oriental del Uruguay, which offered an unexpected bird's-eye view of the plaza.

Regarding existing public art in Buenos Aires, one could say it is really traditional at the moment: you either have official monuments to commemorate the country's and city's history, or street art—there is an amazing tradition of street interventions and graffiti there. But there is another way to think about public art, which is to look at the city as a pedestal. This is what we have tried to do. I think there is a desire among Argentine artists to occupy public space. I remember that the first time I was in Buenos Aires, every single day and everywhere I went there was a protest march. There is this tradition of using public space for activism, which is great. But we also wanted to suggest something else: to activate public space as a quiet space for meditation or for collective experiences that are not necessarily political—like what Maurizio Cattelan proposed with his *Eternity* project in Palermo Park, a temporary cemetery for the living made possible by the participation of hundreds of local artists who were invited to imagine tombstones through an open call. That said, some of the artworks we commissioned were linked to political or social issues. The best example of this is Barbara Kruger's site-specific artwork *Untitled (You Can't Live Without Us)*. There are so many layers to it. First of all, she is highlighting a gorgeous example of industrial architecture, the Silos de la Antigua Junta Nacional de Granos, built at the beginning of the 20th century and located in Puerto Madero, the former harbor that is now one of the liveliest neighborhoods of Buenos Aires thanks to a large-scale regeneration. Her intervention is a way of looking at the city's past. Second, her work is located in front of the Santiago Calatrava's bridge called Puente de la Mujer ("the woman's bridge"), and all the streets nearby are named after female activists, poets, artists, etc. Barbara thus wanted to acknowledge both the building's history and the "female context." The work proved incredibly timely: when we were actually painting it during the summer, there was a legislative vote on

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—Cecilia Alemani



Alexandra Pirici
Aggregate, 2017–2018
Arenas Studios,
La Boca. Buenos Aires

Maurizio Cattelan
Eternity, 2018
Plaza Sicilia, Palermo, Buenos Aires

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abortion—it is illegal in South America except in Uruguay and Argentina. The law [to legalize abortion for all pregnancies up to 14 weeks] did not pass, but it very nearly did. The *porteños* were angry and there were marches in the streets. Barbara's work is not a reference to that particular case, but it somehow met the political agenda.

CD It is a good thing when public art resonates with society, isn't it?

CA Of course! I also think that what makes a public artwork successful is when it allows for multiple readings, when it is not prescriptive. In this case, people were connecting to it in different ways, as a political manifesto, as a celebration of women's accomplishments, as a monumental wall painting. It really engaged different senses and backgrounds.

CD *Hopscotch* also invited people to discover the(ir) city again.

CA Totally! Our idea was to craft a journey through the city that would be a surprise, including for the *porteños*. Eduardo's work is a great example of this, but we also invested in other locations in Costanera Sur like the Museo Ernesto De La Cárcova. It used to be an art school; now it is an incredible museum belonging to the Universidad Nacional de las Artes, conserving a collection of famous replicas—from Michelangelo's *David* to Central American and Indian sculptures. This museum is a kind of time capsule, not very well known. The most common refrain I heard was: "I went there when I was a kid." Santiago de Paoli and Mariela Scafati created words in direct response with this special environment. Working in such spaces was also a way to bring attention to what is already there. I would like to mention also that it was the first time that Mika Rottenberg and Vivian Suter have shown in Argentina, though they were both born there. I was so surprise when I learned about it. It says a lot about what Art Basel Cities can accomplish.

CD Another important element of *Hopscotch* was the performances.

CA We had a few performances by both foreign and Argentine artists. Romanian artist Alexandra Pirici staged *Aggregate*, a "performative environment" that included 60 performers. It was held in another special location: a former power plant where Alex Da Corte also installed his 18-meter-long vinyl inflatable sculpture, *Kermit the Frog, Even*. It provided a very particular stage where Pirici's performers would enact motions and sounds representing our cultural heritage—from ocean waves to Depeche Mode's *Enjoy the Silence*—the kind of shared references that might be fit for a time capsule intended to give future extraterrestrials a sense of life on planet Earth. It was a four-hour event where one could come in at any time, with no real distinction between the audience and the performers. It was really moving and powerful. It is worth mentioning that Buenos Aires has an incredible established tradition of theater and dance, so it was actually quite easy to find performers. Alexandra was really happy with her experience there.

Then we had Gabriel Chaile's public sculpture, which developed in a performative moment. He is a young artist from Tucumán who often works with community-based projects. For *Hopscotch* he created a clay sculpture of anthropomorphic shapes that is actually an oven in which you can cook. It was really a strange encounter to have on the sidewalk of La Boca. After a few days we activated the sculpture by actually cooking empanadas in it and invited the community to come and gather. The work is entitled *Diego (Portrait of Diego Núñez)* in honor of a young boy who was killed by the police. It was very important for Gabriel that Diego's mother, who lives in La Boca, was involved in the project. It was powerful because La Boca is a special place. It is not where tourists go, necessarily. We wanted to do something that would be meaningful for the community. The piece was later donated to Casa San, a foundation in La Boca that supports and protects young kids from trouble.

A third performance was organized by Los Angeles-based artist David Horvitz. He can turn an everyday gesture into something poetic. Held in La Boca, in front of the Biblioteca Nacional Mariano Moreno, and the Ex Cervecería Munich, his *Señalamiento del cielo (Signaling the Sky)* invited the public to release large helium-filled balloons with mile-long strings attached to them. It is a very good example of something that has multiple layers. It was a cheerful and beautiful gesture—kids loved it. It was also an homage to Marcel Duchamp who actually lived in Buenos Aires 100 years ago. Strings were important to Duchamp: they really appeared often in his work, for instance in his labyrinth for the 1942 *International Surrealist Exhibition*, in which artists played hopscotch. There was also a reference to Edgardo Antonio Vigo, an Argentine conceptual artist who, when it was almost impossible to create work during the dictatorship, made art by just pointing at objects.

CD What did you learn from the whole process?

CA It showed us that even if things get complicated, the results can be outstanding. You also need to remember that *Hopscotch* was only one facet of Art Basel Cities Week. For someone closely involved with the whole project, it was fascinating to see how you can engage very diverse audiences with art and culture in so many different ways. The Cultural Partners Program offered many great events, among them Naama Tsabar's site-specific sonic environment at Faena Art Center and Benjamín Felice's solo exhibition at Móvil. I also like the fact that it facilitated Argentine artists and curators meeting people from all over the world and vice versa. I heard from collectors who were pleased to be introduced to Argentine galleries, and I know that some of the participating artists made interesting connections as well. At the same time, so many porteños told me that we managed to reintroduce them to their own city. For *porteños*, what I would call the "pragmatic" part of the program was key: the masterclasses-cum-workshops, in which people could learn about how to make a budget or to open a nonprofit space or residency, make a lot of sense. All this really contributed to making the entire week a celebration of the arts and creativity in Buenos Aires.

It was fascinating to see how you can engage very diverse audiences with art and culture in so many different ways.
—Cecilia Alemani



Ad Minoliti
Symposium for expanded painting and speculative fiction, 2018
Casa Victoria Ocampo, Buenos Aires



Audience members during a talk by Julián Manzelli and Orilo Blandini of the artist collective Doma, with Gala Lucía González, in conversation with curator Rodrigo Alonso, Centro Cultural Recoleta, Buenos Aires, September 9, 2018